Ancient Notes and the Work of Reading

Wall label • 150 words

Ancient notes did several kinds of work. They recorded transactions, preserved extracts, supported new compositions, and helped readers rehearse a way of living. The Greek word hypomnemata could name reminders, records, drafts, or commentaries; it did not specify one notebook design. Seneca asks readers to digest borrowed material until it becomes their own intellectual capacity. Pliny's portrait of his uncle reveals another condition of prolific writing: other people's skilled labor, including the work of enslaved readers and scribes. Surviving wax and wooden tablets let us examine copying, correction, and reuse, but none shown here is Seneca's or Pliny's notebook. For your workbook, preserve the source and document the transformation. Copy a passage, return to it, and make something that changes its use. Then let an AI choose or paraphrase the same material. Compare the results, and ask what you learned by selecting, remembering, checking, and rewriting the words for yourself.

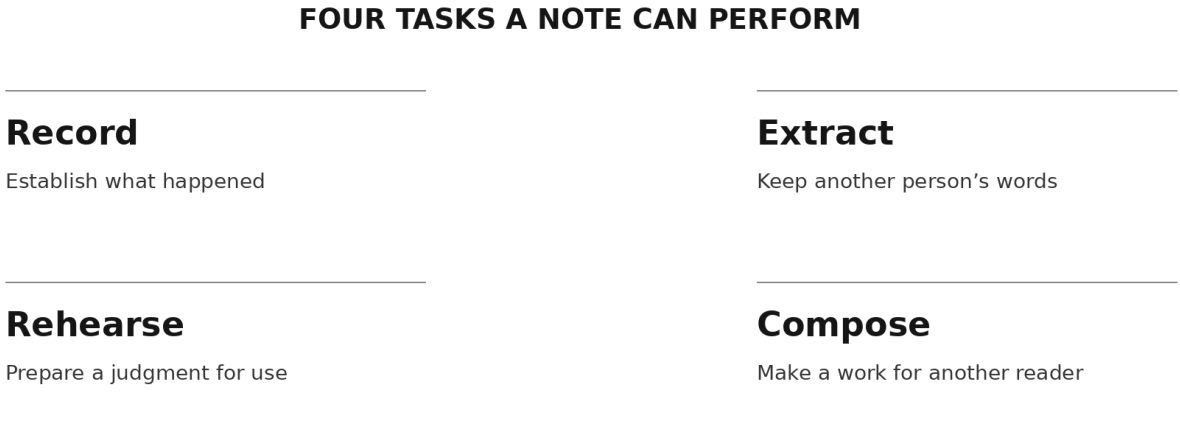


Illustration 1 A modern map of functions, not a reconstruction of an ancient notebook. Ancient examples and source references follow in the essay.

Reading with other people's hands

A reader mispronounces a word at dinner. Someone stops him and asks for the passage again. Pliny the Elder objects: the meaning was understood; the interruption has cost more than ten lines. In his nephew's account, even winter travel becomes an occasion for study. Beside the scholar sits a shorthand writer equipped with a book and small writing tablets, his hands protected against the cold. The detail is almost comic: an entire arrangement of bodies and materials keeps one man's reading moving. These scenes come from Pliny the Younger's Letter 3.5.12–15, written after his uncle's death in 79 CE. The nephew's narrative shapes these habits into a portrait of scholarly industry.[1]

For students assembling workbooks, the scenes suggest a question more interesting than which notebook to buy: what work should a note perform? An ancient record might preserve a transaction; an extract might rescue a passage from a book no longer within reach; a repeated sentence might train someone's response to misfortune. Collected materials could become a new composition. These purposes overlap, but their standards differ. Accuracy matters differently when recording a payment, quoting a poet, or practicing a principle. The object alone cannot tell us which activity is underway.

Ann Blair's history of scholarly information management helps recover these operations behind their finished products. In Too Much to Know, she places ancient excerpting within a longer history of selecting, retaining, and reusing material. She also emphasizes the compatibility of oral reading, dictation, and written collection. A note need not begin with a solitary reader holding a pen. Ancient intellectual production could move through several people before appearing under a single author's name.[2]

One word and several kinds of work

The Greek hypomnēma, plural hypomnēmata, does not designate one standardized notebook. The Liddell–Scott–Jones lexicon records meanings including reminder or memorial, written memorandum, commercial entry, public record, explanatory commentary, and petition to an official. It can also refer to a draft or copy of a letter. A banker's record and a scholar's commentary share a vocabulary of keeping something available; they do not thereby share a page layout, binding, audience, or purpose. The term can describe written content or a textual form rather than a particular portable object.[3]

The range matters because modern accounts sometimes turn hypomnemata into a recognizable lifestyle accessory: the ancient person's book of quotations. Such collections are one possibility within a much larger field. A commentary may follow a source passage by passage and explain its difficulties; a petition addresses someone empowered to act. These are organized around different relationships. Even the apparent opposition between rough notes and finished works cannot supply a universal definition. We must ask what the word means in each passage before imagining what someone held.

Plutarch offers an especially useful instance. At the beginning of On Tranquillity of Mind, he tells Paccius that he has drawn together material from hypomnemata previously made for himself, responding quickly to a request for practical help. W. C. Helmbold's Loeb translation calls these "note-books" (464F–465A). The passage documents an author's claim to reuse his notes for another person's life. It does not preserve the notes themselves or prove their physical format. The claim of hurried preparation may also function as a literary gesture of modesty.[4]

A collection is a resource and a social arrangement

Pliny says his uncle left 160 commentarii of selected material, densely written on both sides (3.5.17). J. B. Firth's translation renders them "commonplace books"; that familiar English phrase must not import the headings, indexes, or bound paper pages of later commonplace systems. The Latin establishes a collection of selections and double-sided writing, not its complete organization. Nor does the letter map particular extracts into particular passages of the Natural History. The collection's role in composition is strongly suggested by the surrounding account of the Elder's output; its precise workflow remains a reconstruction.[1,2]

These materials had value beyond their first reader. The nephew reports an offer of 400,000 sesterces for the collection when it was still smaller. Blair observes that notes could become transferable intellectual resources.[2] Their usefulness potentially exceeded the original collector's memory and intentions. A working collection is personal in its making without necessarily being private in its destiny. Once inherited, purchased, or reshaped, it can support a different writer. Authorship then includes the ability to acquire someone else's accumulated attention.

The arrangement also depended on labor and rank. Letter 3.5 names the reader and shorthand writer by function, without identifying their individual legal statuses. William A. Johnson's study of this episode explicitly foregrounds the enslaved people enabling the Elder's project and the comic impracticalities of his extreme efficiency. The scholarly reconstruction should remain distinguishable from the letter's wording. Servants, including enslaved workers in elite Roman households, could supply skilled reading and writing; carrying the scholar and attending his body also released his attention for study.[5]

Leisure here is not simply an empty afternoon. Pliny's uncle held demanding offices; his nephew depicts him extracting study time from an already busy life. Yet access to books, transport, household assistance, and proximity to imperial power made that extraction possible. Treating his output as a lesson in personal discipline alone would misdescribe the arrangement. It is equally misleading to treat the literary praise as a neutral timetable. The nephew uses his uncle's example to measure his own studiousness and encourage another reader to write.[1,5]

Saving words and changing them

Seneca's Letter 84, composed in the first century CE, asks how reading becomes writing. In Richard M. Gummere's Loeb translation, readers should alternate the two activities, then imitate bees: select from varied reading, keep collected materials distinct, and blend them into something different. Seneca changes metaphors to digestion. Material that remains unchanged has entered memory without becoming the reader's intellectual capacity. He then distinguishes a living resemblance to an admired writer from a lifeless likeness (84.2–8). These images describe transformation; they do not provide instructions for the dimensions or divisions of a notebook.[6]

Selection makes a boundary around attention. Copying slows a sentence enough for its choices to become perceptible: a qualification, an unexpected verb, the point where a comparison stops working. Returning to the extract can expose what the original act of selection overlooked. The collector may discover that the attractive sentence was an objection the author later rejected. Thus extraction creates both an opportunity and a liability. It makes words available for new use while loosening the connections that once governed their meaning.

Margaret Graver's close reading of Letter 84 argues that its account of self-formation must include literary artistry and public writing. Seneca's concern is larger than private therapeutic jotting: a writer harmonizes inherited styles in an artifact others can read. Graver also emphasizes the letter's ethical conclusion and its Stoic commitments. The self taking shape through writing is not whatever personality happens to appeal to its maker.[7] This is consequential for a creative workbook. The transformation of a borrowed sentence can produce a distinctive voice; it still needs an account of what the new work claims and why.

Seneca's own letter makes the relation between borrowing and authorship visible by quoting Virgil while developing the bee comparison (84.3). His method is not a modern citation policy, and the language of assimilation should not authorize hiding sources in student work. For this exhibition, keep two things together: a record accurate enough to recover another author's words, and an experiment that shows what you have done with them. Your contribution may be a new question, an arrangement, a disagreement, or a change of medium. Copying and composing become different acts when their purposes and responsibilities remain legible.

Returning to a sentence as a way of living

Letter 2 offers a smaller scale of collection. Seneca recommends choosing one thought from the day's reading for sustained digestion, and he takes an example from Epicurus despite their different philosophical affiliations (2.4–6). The selected saying becomes material for reconsidering poverty and desire. This is not a command to accumulate endlessly. The important unit is the thought one can stay with.[8] Repetition here gives a borrowed statement further occasions to encounter the reader's judgments.

Epictetus links such return directly to conduct. In Discourses 3.24.103, transmitted by Arrian, he urges keeping the relevant thoughts available day and night, writing and reading them, and discussing them with oneself and others. George Long's translation makes the repeated activities explicit. The surrounding discussion concerns separation, mortality, and what lies beyond one's control.[9] Writing helps prepare a response before the difficult occasion arrives. Possessing a maxim, reciting it, and acting on it are therefore separate achievements. A well-filled collection may still be a poorly used one.

Michel Foucault's 1983 essay on self-writing interprets this material as a practice of forming oneself through received discourse. His account of hypomnemata emphasizes extracts, examples, rereading, and meditation rather than an intimate diary devoted to uncovering hidden feelings.[10] This is a modern philosophical interpretation of selected ancient testimony. It is not an excavated description of one notebook type, nor proof that all educated people followed the same discipline. Graver's criticism supplies a productive check: Foucault's emphasis needs the ancient literary and doctrinal settings it can obscure.[7]

The difference between recording and rehearsal is now clearer. A record may establish that something occurred; an extract keeps a piece of language retrievable; rehearsal aims to make a judgment available under pressure; composition assembles material for a new audience. The same sentence can cross these functions. What changes is the task assigned to it and the action expected after its return. A workbook should make room for those changes rather than assuming that storage already amounts to understanding.

What the surviving surfaces can establish

Wax tablets offered a recessed surface that could be inscribed with a stylus and smoothed for reuse. The British Library's Add MS 34186, from second-century CE Egypt, preserves a model of Greek writing and a learner's repeated copies, including errors. It demonstrates copying and correction in a school setting; it cannot demonstrate the learner's inward assent to the maxim or Seneca's process of digestion.[11]

Papyrus supported reading as well as writing. The Metropolitan Museum's Odyssey fragment, dated about 285–250 BCE, preserves a literary text with lines absent from the standard text now known. It gives material evidence for a book and textual variation, not for a reader's excerpt collection.[12] At Vindolanda, tablet 118 carries a Virgil line on one face and a draft letter on the other. The editors interpret the verse as writing practice and flag uncertainty about which face was used first.[13] Tablet 154, by contrast, records a cohort's strength and availability for service: an administrative snapshot organized for calculation.[14]

These are four visual candidates for four different questions. Their dates and settings must travel with their images. None belongs to the named authors' collections. Neither repeated school writing nor an administrative report should be presented as a surviving philosophical notebook. Aulus Gellius supplies a complementary literary account: in the preface to Attic Nights he describes jottings from reading and hearing, retained for retrieval when books were unavailable. He claims to preserve their miscellaneous order, but supplies summaries to help readers find material (preface 2–3, 25). What survives is his composed work, not the original jottings.[15]

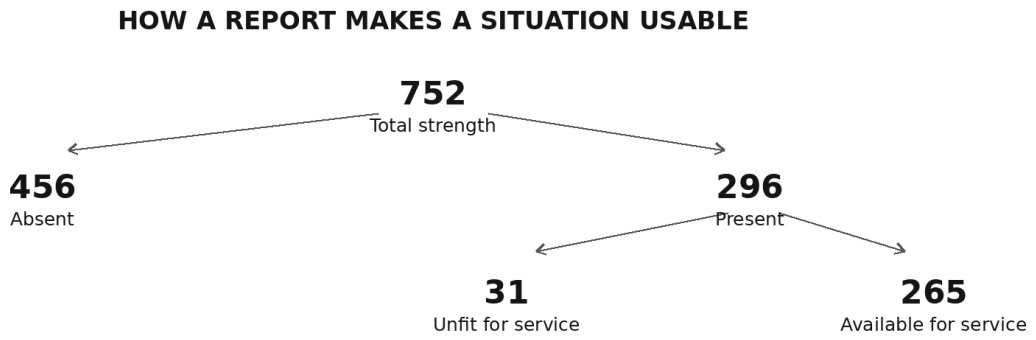


Illustration 2 Modern diagram of the arithmetic in Tab Vindol 154. Values follow the scholarly edition, including restored readings. This is an analysis of the report, not a facsimile. [14]

A studio experiment in returning

Choose three short passages from a text you have read. Copy them exactly; give each an author, title, passage or page reference, and one sentence explaining its surrounding argument. Beside each, record why you selected it. Leave space. Tomorrow, close the source and write what you remember; then reopen it and mark omissions, distortions, and newly noticed details. Rework one passage into a paragraph, dialogue, score, or instruction. Preserve the extract and identify the transformation. Finally, test the new work with someone else: what can they understand or do because of it? This is a contemporary experiment inspired by the evidence, not a reconstructed ancient exercise.

Then give an AI the same source and ask it to select three passages, with exact locations, and paraphrase one. Verify every selection against the source. Compare its choices with yours: which difficulties, surprises, and disagreements disappear? Delegated selection can introduce material you would have missed; it can also give you a collection whose reasons you cannot explain. Delegated paraphrase can accelerate composition while removing the struggle through which you notice what a sentence means. Keep the model's proposal alongside your revision so the division of work remains visible. The experiment asks where transformation occurs: in the retrieved material, in the produced artifact, or in the reader who returns.

Four visual candidates

Repository images for possible exhibition use. These entries identify actual surviving objects; the diagrams in this document are modern analyses. The proposed photographs are linked rather than reproduced.

A model and two attempts

British Library • Add MS 34186

Date Second century CE

Material Wooden tablet with a recessed wax writing surface; Greek letters incised with a stylus

A model appears above repeated learner copies, with omissions and cramped writing. This is direct evidence of a school copying exercise and the material persistence of errors. It cannot establish the learner's beliefs, an adult's practice of philosophical meditation, or the design of Seneca's notes. The repository page reproduces the tablet; select the image identified as Add MS 34186. [11]

Repository record and image

A text available to be read

The Metropolitan Museum of Art • 09.182.50

Date About 285–250 BCE

Material Papyrus bearing a Greek text in ink; surviving fragment of Homer's Odyssey Book 20

This fragment preserves a literary text, including three lines absent from the standard text transmitted today. It shows a material form in which reading was possible and cautions against imagining every ancient reader met an identical text. It is not an excerpt notebook, and no connection to the reading of Seneca or either Pliny is established. Repository image marked Public Domain. [12]

Repository record and image

Four visual candidates

A borrowed verse on a reused surface

British Museum and Roman Inscriptions of Britain • Tab Vindol 118 • BM 1986,1001.128

Date 97–105 CE

Material Ink on a thin wooden writing tablet, surviving in two joining fragments

One face carries a line from Virgil's Aeneid 9.473; the other carries a draft letter. The scholarly edition interprets the verse as writing practice. Reuse is visible, but the order of the two uses is uncertain. This is evidence of copying literary words at a Roman military site, not proof of a maxim collection, a child's identity, or a philosophical author's workbook. The edition links to the museum object. [13]

Repository record and image

A record designed for a decision

British Museum and Roman Inscriptions of Britain • Tab Vindol 154 • BM 1989,0602.21

Date About 92–97 CE; report dated 18 May, year unspecified

Material Oak leaf diptych written in ink across the grain

A strength report separates absent, present, unfit, and available soldiers. Its categories support calculation and administrative use. It records a state of affairs rather than collecting passages from reading. It cannot demonstrate the excerpting described in Pliny or the ethical rehearsal described by Epictetus. The edition identifies uncertain readings and links to the museum object; reproductions should retain those distinctions. [14]

Repository record and image

Sources and evidence notes

References give ancient passage numbers as well as the editions or translations consulted. Modern interpretations, retrospective literary descriptions, and surviving objects are identified separately. Main essay approximately 2080 words; label exactly 150 words.

[1] Pliny the Younger, Letters 3.5, especially §§10–17 and 20. Consulted in J. B. Firth, The Letters of the Younger Pliny (1900), as reproduced with acknowledged minor modifications by Attalus. The Latin was checked for electorum commentarios, opisthographos, pugillaribus, and the sum quadringentis milibus nummum. “Commonplace books” is Firth’s interpretive English, not an ancient physical specification. The letter does not state the individual workers’ legal statuses.

Source or edition

[2] Ann M. Blair, Too Much to Know Managing Scholarly Information before the Modern Age (Yale University Press, 2010), chapter 2, especially pp. 81–83 and 112–113. Used for oral and written collection, ancient reuse of notes, and their exchange value; these pages do not reconstruct an index for Pliny’s lost collection.

Source or edition

[3] Henry George Liddell, Robert Scott, and Henry Stuart Jones, A Greek English Lexicon, s.v. ὑπόμνημα, senses I –IV, consulted through Scaife ATLAS. Examples include Demosthenes 49.5 and 49.30 for bankers’ and commercial memoranda; explanatory commentaries and petitions are separately attested senses.

Source or edition

[4] Plutarch, On Tranquillity of Mind 464E–465A, in Moralia VI, translated by W. C. Helmbold (Loeb Classical Library, 1939). Paccius is the addressee; Fundanus appears in the account of the messenger’s travel. “Note-books” translates hypomnemata but does not establish a binding or page format.

Source or edition

[5] William A. Johnson, “Reading for Efficiency in Ancient Rome The Case of Pliny the Elder,” Reception 15 (2023), pp. 15–23, DOI 10.5325/reception.15.1.0015. Consulted through the author’s institutional abstract, which explicitly states its arguments about enslaved labor and comic impracticality; no unverified details from the full article are attributed here.

Source or edition

[6] Seneca, Moral Letters 84.2–13, in Ad Lucilium Epistulae Morales II, translated by Richard M. Gummere (Loeb Classical Library, 1920), consulted in the Wikisource transcription. The collection and digestion metaphors concern reading, writing, and intellectual transformation; the letter specifies no surviving notebook.

Source or edition

[7] Margaret R. Graver, “Honeybee Reading and Self Scripting Epistulae Morales 84,” in Seneca Philosophus, edited by Jula Wildberger and Marcia L. Colish (De Gruyter, 2014), pp. 269–293, especially pp. 273–276 and 281–291. Consulted in a digitized volume; used for the literary dimensions of Seneca’s argument and the limits of Foucault’s reading.

Source or edition

[8] Seneca, Moral Letters 2.1–6, translated by Richard M. Gummere, Ad Lucilium Epistulae Morales I (Loeb Classical Library, 1917). Daily selection and Epicurus appear at §§4–6.

Source or edition

[9] Epictetus, Discourses 3.24.103, reported by Arrian; consulted in George Long, The Discourses of Epictetus with the Encheiridion and Fragments (1877). The Wikisource chapter does not print modern subsection numbers; the pertinent paragraph begins “Let these thoughts be ready to hand by night and by day.” This is transmitted teaching, not an autograph notebook.

Source or edition

[10] Michel Foucault, “L’écriture de soi,” Corps écrit 5 (1983), pp. 3–23; consulted as “Writing the Self,” translated by Ann Hobart, reproduced in The Montréal Review (June 2024). This is modern interpretation. Its reference to Fundanus as the requester of Plutarch’s advice should be checked against the ancient opening, which addresses Paccius; the essay here follows the primary text.

Source or edition

[11] Peter Toth and Alan E. Cole, “Keep taking the wax tablets,” British Library, 8 May 2019, especially the illustration and description of Add MS 34186. Used for the school tablet’s date, material, copying, and errors; broader origin stories in the post are not relied upon.

Source or edition

[12] The Metropolitan Museum of Art, collection record 09.182.50, “Papyrus fragment with lines from Homer’s Odyssey.” Repository dating, medium, and textual description consulted. The fragment’s use as a reading object is distinct from any claim about excerpting.

Source or edition

[13] Alan K. Bowman and J. David Thomas, The Vindolanda Writing Tablets II (1994), no. 118, with online edition and commentary at Roman Inscriptions of Britain. The dating is contextual. The edition explicitly notes uncertainty about the order of use of the two faces.

Source or edition

[14] Bowman and Thomas, The Vindolanda Writing Tablets II, no. 154, online edition and commentary at Roman Inscriptions of Britain. Used for oak, the date range, the report’s categories, and its administrative function. The document is not classified by its editors as a straightforward daily report or pridianum.

Source or edition

[15] Aulus Gellius, Attic Nights, preface §§2–4, 11–12, 25; translated by John C. Rolfe (Loeb Classical Library, 1927, revised 1946). The preface supplies an author’s retrospective description of gathering and presenting notes; it is not the original working archive.

Source or edition